JYOTI TUTU, 57
RAJAJI TUTU, 59

Now living in Jagti Colony, Nagrota, Jammu; originally residing in Srinagar

Fled the valley in April 1990

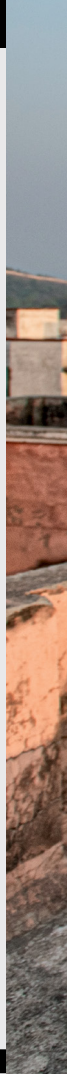
Just off the Jammu-Srinagar highway, the Jagti township in Nagrota is a sprawling colony of over 4,000 two-room houses the state government built in 2008 to be allotted to Kashmiri Pandits who had fled to Jammu. The township was among three such settlements built with central assistance—the other two being in Muthi and Purkhoo near Jammu city. Rajaji and Jyoti were fortunate to be allotted one of the flats in Jagti and moved there 12 years ago with their two daughters. The rooms may be small, but, as Jyoti says, compared to their tented accommodation, it is infinitely better.

While Rajaji was a medical representative, Jyoti was the principal of a school when the situation deteriorated rapidly for the Pandits. Jyoti recalls that when there was a cricket match, there was widespread support for Pakistan among a section of the Muslims. Hindu houses would be stoned if Pakistan lost a match. As death threats increased, they decided to flee to Jammu, where they had to face great hardships. Yet they ensured that their two daughters got a good education. "Long before Modi ji advocated Beti Padhao, we were doing it," says Jyoti. They have not been back to the Valley so far and don't want to either. "We don't want to live in fear as we did before," says Jyoti. "Nor will I allow my children to experience fear. We will sit here peacefully and chant the name of Lord Ram."

"WE DON'T WANT TO [GO BACK TO THE VALLEY AND] LIVE IN FEAR. NOR WILL I ALLOW MY CHILDREN TO EXPERIENCE FEAR"

On his part, Rajaji says he had pinned his hopes on Prime Minister Narendra Modi, but feels let down because his government has paid no heed to the demands of the Pandits. He says, "I can write it on my hand that abrogating 370 was a blunder. It is no use to us. Many Kashmiri Pandits are still looking for houses and jobs and nothing much has been done for us on these two fronts." Rajaji believes that Kashmir as an issue will never be solved as long as Pakistan is there. "We are not destined to live in peace," he says despondently.

–Raj Chengappa



spread allegations of rigging. Farooq Abdullah denies the charge, but it had a severe fallout. Mohammed Yusuf Shah, an MUF candidate for Srinagar's Amira Kadal constituency, alleged that he was leading by a huge margin before the election was snatched from him. He was arrested and put in jail. So was Yasin Malik, who was heading the Islamic Students' League at the time and had campaigned for him. After their release in 1989, Yusuf Shah joined the Hizbul Mujahideen (HM) and adopted the nom de guerre Syed Salahuddin. Malik joined three other militants to form the core of the Indian wing of the Jammu Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF). They crossed over to Pakistan soon after, as did Salahuddin and hundreds of other Kashmiris, where the ISI reportedly gave them training in arms and explosives. They returned and took violent insurgency to a level from which Kashmir has never recovered. Farooq was accused of being Kashmir's Nero, more interested in having fun and travelling abroad than attending to serious affairs of the state.

Pandits became the primary target because **they could be easily terrorised;** attacks on just a few would force all to flee the Valley

Dissent and divisions in the Indian political and security establishments would only aid Pakistan's malicious intentions. In the 1989 general election, Rajiv lost power to a coalition of parties that included the Janata Dal, led by V.P. Singh, his former finance and defence minister who had resigned from the Congress, supported by the L.K. Advani-led BJP. Singh appointed Mufti Mohammed Sayeed, a prominent Kashmiri leader and Farooq Abdullah's arch-rival, as his home minister. Taking advantage of the political flux, the militants launched a series of terror attacks in the Valley. On August 15 that year, they declared a blackout day, asking all Kashmiris to keep their lights off through the night in protest. Mohammed Yusuf Halwai, an NC official, defied the order and had all lights on in his house. A week later, he was shot dead. A spate of killings of prominent individuals followed, including the assassination of Neelkanth Ganjoo, a judge who had sentenced Bhat to death, as well as Doordarshan director Lassa Kaul and many security personnel. Both Farooq and Mufti were accused of inaction while Kashmir burned.

The tide would turn decisively